At the time of the insurgency itself, in an interview, Baruah had echoed a similar opinion. Answering a direct question, ‘Do they [the tea companies] pay you?’, he had said, ‘Yes, many of them do. But Tata Tea is the only one who has not. They are difficult customers. We did not touch them after they said no to our request for payments … They were doing some work for Assam. We knew their work made them popular in Assam.’

Most importantly, some years later, in 2001, Union Disinvestment Minister Arun Shourie, while answering a supplementary question in Parliament, confirmed that investigations by the Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW), the IB and the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) ‘had found no substance in the charge that the Tatas had financed ULFA in the North East’.

Fighting a popular government and a ruthless militia without compromising on the group’s principles was indeed a difficult task. The fact that the ULFA problems erupted at a time when Ratan was battling the antagonism of the old guard at Bombay House only made things harder for him. He engaged delicately with his detractors to disarm them, a strategy that he most effectively employed when all else appeared futile. Ratan was able to neutralize their combined animosity, standing steadfast against all odds. It was a turbulent time that would have tested the resolve of the most seasoned of industrialists.